

The Everyday Guide to Claude

For portfolio managers and analysts. No code, no jargon — just how to get good, trustworthy work out of Claude. Keep it by your desk.

The one idea to remember. Claude is not a search box — it's a very capable, very fast junior colleague who has read almost everything but knows nothing about *your* standards until you tell it. Brief it the way you'd brief a sharp new analyst, and it will work the way you want. Brief it vaguely, and you'll get vague work.

What it is, in one minute

Claude is a frontier AI model. In a chat window it answers questions; given a folder and some tools (that's **Cowork**), it actually *does the work* — reads filings, drafts notes, builds spreadsheets, browses IR sites — and shows you every step.

Skills are short plain-English instruction files that teach it your house style so you don't repeat yourself. Everything it does sits behind a permission prompt; nothing happens silently.

How to ask well — the four-part brief

Almost every good prompt has four parts. Miss one and quality drops.

Part	What to give it	Example
Goal	The outcome you want, plainly	"Compare Shoprite and Pick n Pay's latest margins"
Format	Shape of the answer	"...as a short table, then two sentences of read"
Guardrails	What it must / must never do	"Cite every number; don't guess — say 'not disclosed'"
Context	Period, scope, which docs	"...latest reported period, from our downloaded filings"

Ten prompts you can use today

Copy these, swap the names. They already include the guardrails that keep the output trustworthy.

Get up to speed

COMPANY SNAPSHOT

Tell me about Capitec – latest results, headline numbers vs the prior period, and the three things management flagged. Cite your sources.

See what's new

SENS SWEEP

What SENS announcements have our watchlist names published in the last 7 days, and which look material? Give source and date for each.

Compare two names

PEER COMPARE

Compare Mr Price and Woolworths on revenue growth, gross margin and trading density, latest period. Cite every figure and note any period mismatch.

Pressure-test the work

SELF-CHECK

Re-read your last answer and list every figure you stated, with the document and page it came from. Flag any you cannot source.

Summarise a document

ONE-PAGE SUMMARY

Summarise this results PDF in one page: what moved, why, and what's changed since last period. Mark anything you're inferring as an estimate.

Turn it into a spreadsheet

TO EXCEL

Put that peer comparison into a formatted Excel workbook: one row per company, a ratios tab, conditional formatting on leverage. Keep every figure cited.

Draft in house style

IC ONE-PAGER

Draft an IC one-pager on Clicks from our latest note: thesis, key metrics vs pcg, risks, what would change our mind. Informational only; cite everything.

Make a reusable capability

NEW SKILL

Create a skill that turns a results PDF into our standard one-page summary: metrics vs pcg, margin bridge, guidance, risk flags. Never invent a number.

What it's great at — and where you stay in charge

Claude carries the routine 80%

- Finding and reading filings — hundreds of pages, fast
- Re-keying and cross-checking numbers
- First drafts in your format
- Tireless, consistent, available before the open

You keep the 20% that matters

- Judgement and conviction — the actual call
- Client and management relationships
- Accountability and sign-off
- Knowing when the number *feels* wrong

Five things to never skip

1. **Ask for sources.** "Cite every number to document and page." It turns a black box into something you can spot-check in seconds.

2. **Always demand the prior-period comparison.** A number alone means little; current vs pcp vs change is the minimum.
3. **Give it an honest out.** Tell it to write "not disclosed" rather than guess.
4. **Read before you rely.** Nothing leaves the building without your eyes on it.
5. **Mind closed periods.** Ask it to flag any name in a prohibited dealing window.

When it can be wrong (and how you'd catch it)

It can be confidently wrong (a "hallucination"). Fluent does not mean correct. That's exactly why we insist on citations — a wrong figure that's cited to a page is caught in seconds when you check the page.

It can lose the plot if overloaded (the "dumb zone"). Ask one clear thing at a time. A focused question gets a sharper answer than a sprawling one.

If it goes wrong — quick fixes

What you see	What to do
Answer feels generic or off-target	Add the missing brief part (goal/format/guardrails/context) and ask again
A number looks wrong	"Show me the document and page for that figure" — then check it
It made something up	"Only use our downloaded documents; if it's not there, say so"
Output too long / wrong shape	Tell it the format: "one page", "a table", "three bullets"
It won't open a file / website	The file may be outside the working folder, or the site blocks fetches — flag to the builder/IT

Need more? The hands-on companion — writing your own skills, the workspace, connectors — is in **The Builder's Guide**. Stuck on something live? Ask Claude itself: "how should I phrase this?" is a perfectly good prompt. • *Informational use only; not investment advice.*